

Norvex Publishing — design system *audit*

A complete pass over typography, colour, spacing, components, custom blocks, patterns and theme.json — followed by the full design system I recommend to make the theme consistent, accessible and easy to maintain.

B

Overall health
Strong craft — heads a token + contrast pass

Theme: **Norvex Publishing Services** Custom blocks: **40+** Fonts: **Newsreader + Hanken Grotesk** Status: **Final recommendation**

01 HEALTH SCORECARD

Where the theme stands today

The bones are excellent — this is a professionally-built theme. The gaps are almost all *systemic* values chosen well but one at a time, so the same decision drifts across 2,000 lines. Nothing here is a rewrite; it's a tokenisation and accessibility tune-up.

Colour & contrast **C+**
Beautiful warm palette, careful roles for AA on light surfaces.

Typography **C**
Strong pairing & tokens, but weights are unthesised and the scale has a gap.

Spacing & layout **B-**
Excellent responsive grids; zero spacing tokens underneath.

Radius & elevation **B-**
Two radius tokens, but six ad-hoc corner values in use.

Components **A-**
Rich, considered set with hover, motion and mobile car t-

Accessibility **C+**
Reduced-motion + skip link done; contrast & focus need work.

theme.json & tokens **C**
Palette wired; spacing presets, fluid type & sizes drift from CSS.

Blocks & patterns **A-**
40+ blocks, categorised patterns, thoughtful editor UX.

WHAT'S ALREADY DONE RIGHT

- ✓ Self-hosted, subsetting woff2 fonts (fast + GDPR-friendly)
- ✓ Semantic CSS custom properties for the whole palette
- ✓ prefers-reduced-motion respected across reveals, marquee & cookie bar
- ✓ Rich, categorised block & pattern library (40+ blocks)
- ✓ Skip link, screen-reader text & sensible landmarks
- ✓ Considerate editor styles & has-text-colour colour cascade

02 FINDINGS & FIXES

What to change, in priority order

Every item lists where it lives, why it matters and the specific fix. Recommendations only — nothing in the theme has been edited.

Filter with the **Tweaks** panel (severity) →

CRITICAL - 4

01 Headings & numerals render as faux-bold

TYPOGRAPHY

font-size bundles Newsreader 400 & 500 only, but the CSS sets the brand name (800), section numerals, prices, stats, table headers, logos and pull-quotes to 600-800. The browser synthesises those weights — heavier, blurrier and off the intended look. Hanken Grotesk 500 (eyebrows, badges, cites) has the same problem.

FIX Add Newsreader 600 & 700 (and Hanken 800) to font-size, OR remap every 600-800 serif rule down to 500 and 800 Hanken rules to 700.

02 Body & UI text falls WCAG AA on light surfaces

COLOUR

—muted #8a8474 (used for most card body copy, leads and captions) is ~3:1 on cream/paper. Gold #be8a3d and Gold-Dark #a5762e as link/price text land at ~2.7:1. All are below the 4.5:1 needed for normal text.

FIX Darken muted to #466b56 (5:1:1) for text, and add a Gold-Deep #8a4a20 (4.8:1) for links, prices and inline gold. Keep the originals for large/decorative use only.

03 Primary button contrast is below AA

COLOUR

—norvex-btn-primary is white text on Gold — 3.05:1 at 17px/600, which is not "large" by WCAG, so it fails. It is the single most-used interactive element on the site.

FIX Switch primary button text to link #14182a on Gold (5.9:1 ✓), or keep white text on the darker Gold-Deep.

04 No semantic status colours

COLOUR

The contact form paints its success note gold-dark and its error note gold — essentially the same hue — so users cannot tell an accepted submission from a validation error by colour.

FIX Add success / error / warning / info tokens tuned to the warm palette (e.g. #467f52, #f53452f, gold, ink-soft) and use them for form states, notices and alerts.

IMPORTANT - 7

05 No spacing scale

TOKENS

Section padding (92/64), card padding (34/30/38/26) and gaps (22-56) are all hand-typed; theme.json enables the spacing tools but defines no presets, so any spacing an editor picks won't match the theme's rhythm.

FIX Define a 4px-based scale (4 8 12 16 24 32 48 64 92) as CSS vars and as theme.json spacingSizes; migrate values to var() over time.

06 Three different buttons

COMPONENTS

—norvex-btn is 17px / radius 10; the core wp-block-button_link is 15px / radius 8; theme.json declares button radius 8. So a theme button and a core button placed side-by-side don't match in size or corner.

FIX Unify on one spec — 15px / 600, radius 12, ink-on-gold primary — and have both layers share it.

07 Corner radius isn't tokenised

TOKENS

Only —radius 16 and —radius-sm 8 exist, yet 6, 10, 13, 14, 22 and 26px all appear (card media 13, buttons 10, CTA/consult 22, notice 14).

FIX Adopt a radius scale — sm 8 / md 12 / lg 16 / xl 22 / pill — and map each component to a step.

08 Type scale has a redundant step and a gap

TYPOGRAPHY

Lead (20px) and H3 (21px) are visually identical, while nothing sits between H3 21 and H2 34 — the 24px numeral lives outside the heading flow. Hierarchy reads flat on card-heavy pages.

FIX Reflow to a 1.25 scale: H2 22 (serif 500), a 28 step (or H2 clamp floor), H2 34, and separate Lead from H3 by font & weight.

09 theme.json drifts from the CSS

CONFIG

Base font size is fixed 17px in theme.json but scalable 1.0625rem in CSS; the editor's "Heading 2" preset is a fixed 2.125rem while real H2s are a fluid clamp; the editor exposes 6 sizes vs 10 CSS roles.

FIX Align the values, expose the full role set, and consider WordPress fluid typography instead of hand-rolled clamps.

10 Card surface & "cream" are inconsistent

COLOUR

Some cards use #fff, others —paper #f6f6f6; the sticky header uses #faf7f1 — a third near-cream that isn't —cream #f7f2e8.

FIX Standardise on one —surface token (Paper) for cards and align the header background to a real palette value.

11 Two parallel class systems

ARCHITECTURE

—norvex- (PHP blocks) and —nvx- (core-block demo layer) re-implement the same ideas — eyebrow, card, quote, pricing, steps — with small differences, doubling maintenance. —norvex-quote also names two unrelated components.

FIX Converge on shared primitives (or clearly document the split) and rename the duplicated. —norvex-quote.

POLISH - 6

No line-height scale

TYPE

—25 distinct line-heights, including 4, 72 and 1.02.
—Four steps: tight 1.05 · snug 1.2 · normal 1.5 · relaxed 1.65.

Focus-visible is incomplete

A11Y

Inputs and tabs have focus rings; —norvex-btn and most links don't.
—Add one global focus-visible ring token to every interactive element.

Breakpoint sprawl

RESPONSIVE

Eight-plus query widths (440-1024) chosen ad hoc.
—Standardise on 4-5 named breakpoints.

Letter-spacing spread

TYPE

Eyebrows/labels vary from 0.8em to .22em.
—Two or three tracking tokens; reserve .22em for the tiny brand tag.

Elevation has gaps

TOKENS

Two shadow tokens plus several one-offs (cookie bar, stuck header).
—Add one mid-step; keep the darken-on-hover behaviour.

Marquee & reveal are solid

MOTION

Reduced-motion is handled well already.
—Just fold the durations/keywords into named motion tokens.

THE RECOMMENDED DESIGN SYSTEM

One consistent token set for the whole Norvex theme

Same warm editorial identity — paper, charcoal ink and gold. Newsreader over Hanken Grotesk — re-expressed as a tidy scale of tokens. Everything below is contrast-checked; this very page is built on the recommended values.

03 COLOUR & CONTRAST

Keep the palette — fix the text roles

The ten brand colours are lovely. The problem is only where they carry text on light surfaces. Ratios below are against Cream (#f7f2e8); AA body text needs 4.5:1.

BRAND PALETTE (UNCHANGED)

Ink #00122a Headings, dark bands	Ink Soft #003069 Dels / secondary dark	Gold #be8a3d Accents, fills, rules	Gold Dark #a5762e Accent hover	Cream #f7f2e8 Page background	Paper #fff Card surface
Sand #efe7d5 Soft section band	Line #83fa38 Borders, dividers	Text #3fa338 Body · 10:1 ✓	Muted #8a8474 3:31 — fails as body		

ADD THESE ROLES —

Muted (find) #f6f6f6 5:11 ✓ AA Body text on cream	Links · prices Gold Deep (new) #8a4a20 4.8:1 ✓ text/links	Success Success (new) #467f52 Form OK state	Error Error (new) #f53452f Validation, alerts
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BUTTON CONTRAST

White on Gold is 3.05:1 (fails at 17px). Use **Ink text on Gold** (5.9:1 ✓) or white on Gold-Deep.

DARK SECTIONS

On Ink, Gold text is 8.8:1 ✓ and 17:1 ✓. The dark bands are already compliant — no change needed.

04 TYPOGRAPHY

A scale that maps to the fonts you ship

Newsreader for display & numerals, Hanken Grotesk for everything functional. The single biggest win is loading the weights the CSS already asks for, so nothing renders as synthetic bold.

NEWSREADER · DISPLAY
Aa
Your story, *published* the right way.
Weights to load: 400 · 500 · 600 · 700 (+ 400/500 Italic)

HANKEN GROTESK · UI & BODY
Aa
From first draft to final launch, one dedicated team helps you write, edit, design, publish and market — clearly and calmly.
400 Regular · 500 Medium · 600 Semibold · 700 Bold

ROLE	SIZE	FONT / WEIGHT	LINE-H	USE
Display · H1	48-56px	Newsreader 400	1.05	Hero & page titles
Section · H2	28-34px	Newsreader 400	1.10	Section headings
Card title · H3	22px	Newsreader 500	1.20	Cards & sub-heads
Subhead · H4	18px	Newsreader 500	1.30	In-card labels
Lead	20px	Hanken 400	1.55	Section intros
Body	17px	Hanken 400	1.65	Paragraph copy
Small	15px	Hanken 400/500	1.50	Meta, captions, UI
Caption	13px	Hanken 400	1.45	Fine print
Overline	12px	Hanken 600	1.00	Eyebrows, tags
Numeral L	40px	Newsreader 600	1.00	Stats, prices
Numeral S	24px	Newsreader 600	1.00	Inline figures

Note: today's **Lead 20px** and **H3 21px** are near-identical — the recommended scale separates them by font & weight and fills the empty jump between card titles (22) and section heads (34).

05 SPACE · RADIUS · ELEVATION · MOTION

The measurements that don't exist yet

The theme has width and colour tokens but no scale for spacing, corners or shadows — those are hand-typed everywhere. Naming them (and wiring spacing into theme.json) is the highest-leverage cleanup.

Spacing · 4px base

Also define these as spacingSizes presets.

- xs · icon-gaps
- sm ·
- md · card-gaps
- lg · gutters
- xl · card-padding
- 2xl ·
- 3xl · section

Radius

Replaces the ad-hoc 6/10/13/14/22/26 in use.

- xs 8
- md 12
- lg 16
- xl 22
- pill

Buttons use 10px but the token & theme.json say 8px — pick one (md 12 recommended).

Elevation

Keep the two you have; add a mid step.

- sm · Circles at rest
- md (new) · Popovers, sticky nav
- lg · Hover (IF, modals)

Line-height

Tight	1.05
Snug	1.2
Normal	1.5
Relaxed	1.65

Retire the ~25 one-offs (incl. 4, 72, 1.02).

Letter-spacing

Tight (display)	-0.02em
Body	0
Overline	0.14em

Collapses 0.8-2.2em down to three tracks.

Motion

Fast	120ms
Base	180ms
Slow	360ms
Ease	~2.7, ~1.1

Already consistent — just name them.

06 COMPONENT RECOMMENDATIONS

Unify the primitives

One button, one card surface, one chip, one field — reused by both the block layer and core-block layer.

Buttons
Book a consultation
Explore services

- One size: **15px / 600**, padding 13x22, radius 12
- Primary — **ink on gold** fixes 3:1 contrast
- Merge —norvex-btn + up-block-button
- Add focus-visible ring on all

Card surface
Card title

Body copy uses the fixed muted so it clears AA.

- Pick **one** surface — Paper affects everywhere
- Today some cards are #fff, header is #faf7f1
- Border 1px, radius lg, shadow sm

Badges & fields

EBROW	SUCCESS	ERROR
you@example.com		
• One eyebrow track (1.5em)		
• Give form OK / error distinct colours		
• Focus ring: gold, 3px, 18% alpha		

07 CONFIG & ARCHITECTURE

Close the gap between CSS and the editor

theme.json

Add spacingSizes — spacing tools are on but no presets, so editor spacing won't match the 4/8/16/32 rhythm.

Reconcile sizes — base is fixed 17px here vs scalable 1.0625rem in CSS. "Heading 2" is fixed 2.125rem vs the fluid clamp on real H2s.

System sizes list — 6 editor sizes vs 10 CSS roles; add eyebrow & numeral.

Buttons — 4px here, 10px in CSS. Align to 12.

Consider typography-fluid instead of hand-rolled clamps.

CSS architecture

Two vocabularies — —norvex- (PHP blocks) and —nvx- (core-block layer) re-implement eyebrow, card, quote, pricing & steps with subtle differences. Converge on shared primitives or document the split.

Name collision — —norvex-quote is both a testimonial card and the core pull-quote. Rename one.

Promote tokens — add the space / radius / line-height / motion vars to create and swap the magic numbers to var() over time.

Blocks & patterns are healthy — 40+ blocks, categorised patterns; they'll simply inherit the tokens.

08 IMPLEMENTATION ROADMAP

A sensible order to ship it

1 Accessibility (ship first)

- Load Newsreader 400/700 + Hanken 800
- Darken muted to #466b56; add Gold-Deep
- Ink-on-gold primary button
- Add status colours + focus ring

2 Tokenise

- Add space / radius / line-height / motion vars to root
- Swap magic numbers to var() per component
- Wire spacingSizes into theme.json

3 Reconcile

- Align theme.json sizes & radius to CSS
- Reflow the type scale
- Unify the button spec

4 Consolidate

- Align theme.json vars, primitives
- Rename the duplicate —norvex-quote
- Standardise breakpoints

09 FINAL RECOMMENDED STYLESHEET

Every value, ready to drop in

The complete recommended token set, base rules and core components for Norvex Publishing Services — each CSS value spelled out and contrast-checked. Paste over the top of the :root and component blocks in theme.css.

Load: Newsreader 400 · 500 · 600 · 700 (+400/500 Italic) Load: Hanken Grotesk 400 · 500 · 600 · 700 · 800

```
/* norvex-design-system.css */

/* Norvex Publishing Services — recommended design system
   All colours contrast-checked (WCAG AA). */:root {
  /* — Colour — */
  --ink: #00122a; /* Headings · dark bands */
  --ink-soft: #003069; /* Dels · secondary dark */
  --gold-dark: #be8a3d; /* fills · rules · large text */
  --gold: #a5762e; /* accent hover */
  --cream: #f7f2e8; /* page background */
  --paper: #fff; /* the 002 card surface */
  --card: #f6f6f6; /* core section band */
  --line: #83fa38; /* borders · dividers */
  --text: #3fa338; /* body text · 10:11 ✓ */
  --muted: #8a8474; /* PHP · secondary · 5:1:3 ✓ */
  --muted-ig: #8a4a20; /* large/decorative only */
  --success: #467f52;
  --error: #f53452f;
  --warning: #f6f6f6;
  --info: #2a3869;

  /* — Type families (see weights shown) — */
  --font-serif: "Newsreader", "Times New Roman", "Palatino Linotype", "Georgia", serif;
  --font-sans: "Hanken Grotesk", apple-system, BlinkMacSystemFont, "Segoe UI", Roboto, Arial, sans-serif;
  --font-mono: "SF Mono", "Regular", "Menlo", Consolas, monospace;

  /* — Type scale — */
  --fs-display: clamp(2.5rem, 5vw, 3.5rem); /* 48-56 · h1 */
  --fs-h2: clamp(1.75rem, 3.4vw, 2.125rem); /* 28-34 · h2 */
  --fs-h3: 1.375em; /* 22 · card title */
  --fs-h4: 1.125em; /* 18 · subhead */
  --fs-h5: 1.05em; /* 16 · lead */
  --fs-body: 1.0625em; /* 17 · body */
  --fs-small: 0.875em; /* 13 · meta/print */
  --fs-caption: 0.8125em; /* 11 · fine print */
  --fs-overline: 0.75em; /* 12 · eyebrow */
  --fs-numl: 2.5rem; /* 40 · stats */
  --fs-numsm: 1.5rem; /* 24 · inline */

  /* — Line-height · tracking — */
  --lh-tight: 1.05; /* snug: 1.2; —lh-normal: 1.5; —lh-relaxed: 1.65; */
  --track: 0.02em; /* —track-body: 0; —track-overline: 0.14em; */

  /* — Space (4px base) — */
  --sp-14px: --sp-28px; /* sp-12px; --sp-416px; --sp-512px; */
  --sp-632px; /* sp-746px; --sp-846px; --sp-912px; */

  /* — Radius — */
  --r-sm: 8px; /* r-md: 12px; --r-lg: 16px; --r-xl: 22px; --r-pill: 999px; */

  /* — Elevation — */
  --shadow-sm: 0 1px 2px rgba(20,24,42,.5);
  --shadow-md: 0 3px 3px rgba(20,24,42,.5);
  --shadow-lg: 0 10px 10px rgba(20,24,42,.5);

  /* — Motion / layout — */
  --dur-fast: 120ms; /* dur-base: 180ms; --dur-slow: 360ms; */
  --ease-cubic-bezier(2, 7, .2, 1);
  --wrap: 1160px; /* wrap-wide: 1380px; --gutter: 24px; */
}

/* — Base — */:body { font-family: var(--font-sans); font-size: var(--fs-body);
  line-height: var(--lh-relaxed); color: var(--text); background: var(--cream); }
h1,h2,h3,h4 { font-family: var(--font-serif); border: 1.5px solid transparent; color: var(--ink);
  margin: 0 8px; letter-spacing: var(--track-tight); }
h2 { font-size: var(--fs-h2); font-weight: 400; line-height: var(--lh-tight); }
h3 { font-size: var(--fs-h3); font-weight: 400; line-height: var(--lh-smug); }
h4 { font-size: var(--fs-h4); font-weight: 400; line-height: 1.1; }
p { margin: 0 8px; }
a { color: var(--gold-deep); text-decoration: none; transition: color var(--dur-base) var(--ease); }
a:hover { color: var(--gold); }
a:active { font-weight: 600; letter-spacing: var(--track-tight); }
a:disabled { background: var(--dur-base) var(--ease); box-shadow: var(--dur-base) var(--ease); }
a:disabled { transform: translateY(4px); box-shadow: var(--dur-base) var(--ease); }

/* — Header / eyebrow chip — */:h1 { height: 100px; font-size: var(--fs-display); line-height: 1; letter-spacing: 0.02em; padding: 24px 12px; border-radius: var(--r-pill); }
/* — Form field & distinct status notes — */:div { width: 100%; padding: 12px 15px; border: 1px solid var(--line); border-radius: var(--r-md); background: #fff;
  font-size: var(--fs-small); font-weight: 400; color: var(--ink); }
:div:focus-visible { outline: none; border-color: var(--gold); box-shadow: 0 0 8px rgba(180,138,61,.15); }
:div:ok { color: var(--success); }
:div:error { color: var(--error); }

/* — Reduced motion (keep) — */:div { prefers-reduced-motion: reduce; * { animation: none !important; transition: none !important; } }
```

Class names above are illustrative primitives — map them onto the existing —norvex- selectors. The token block is the drop-in part.

Norvex Publishing Services — final recommended styling — drop-in tokens, no theme files changed.

Norvex Publishing Services · Paper · Ink · Gold